

Make an Army memo with AI. Start here.

AI FUNDAMENTALS IN HEALTH CARE
COACHING NOTE · LTC JARED BLACK

You watched me generate an AR 25-50 memo in seconds during class and asked how it's done. Here it is — the simple way first. Do this once and you'll have a clean, compliant MFR tonight.

You never learn to code.

The AI writes the formatting; you copy and paste it. You never type or edit any of it.

You install nothing.

The fast path runs entirely in your web browser. No software, no IT ticket.

About 15 minutes.

That's the first time, while you find the buttons. After that it's about 3 minutes a memo.

Why not just use Word? Word can't guarantee the exact AR 25-50 margins, fonts, and spacing — you end up fiddling. This routes through a tool that nails the format *perfectly, every time*. You still never format anything by hand.

THE FAST PATH — DO THIS TONIGHT

Ask Sage → Overleaf

BROWSER ONLY · ~15 MIN FIRST TIME

YOU'LL NEED · An [Ask Sage](#) account (the DoD-authorized, CUI-approved AI — you likely already have access) and a free [Overleaf](#) account. Plus the attached **STARTER KIT** (a zip — just unzip it).

NOT SURE YOU HAVE ASK SAGE? Go to [asksage.ai](#) — Army CAC users sign in at [chat.genai.army.mil](#) — and try your login. No access? Email me; for non-sensitive practice you can do the writing step in any commercial AI (ChatGPT or Claude) instead.

PART A · WRITE IT (ASK SAGE)

- 1 Unzip the starter kit. (Nothing goes to the AI — you'll only upload two files to Overleaf later.)
- 2 Log in to [Ask Sage](#) and start a new prompt. In the model dropdown, pick the most capable model offered (the newest GPT or Claude, usually at the top).
- 3 Open `sample-prompt.md` from the kit, copy the whole thing, and paste it into Ask Sage. The memo format is *built into the prompt* — no file uploads needed.
- 4 Fill the `[brackets]` with your memo facts, then send.
- 5 Ask Sage replies with the LaTeX. Click **Copy** — but copy **only the code**: it must start with `\documentclass`. Delete any ````` lines or sentences it adds.

PART B · GET THE PDF (OVERLEAF)

- 1 Go to [overleaf.com](#) → sign up free → **New Project** → Blank Project.
- 2 Click **Upload** and add `armymemo.cls` and `D0Db1.pdf` from the kit.
- 3 Paste the copied LaTeX into the main file (replace what's there).
- 4 **Important:** [Menu](#) → [Compiler](#) → [LuaLaTeX](#) (not the default). Click **Recompile**.
- 5 Click **Download PDF**. That's your memo.
- 6 **Blanks?** Anywhere the AI lacked a fact shows an underline. Find the matching `\rule{...}` in the source, type your text over it, Recompile.

Two non-negotiables — these matter more than any step above

1. Mind where the words go. Ask Sage is a government, CUI-approved system — fine for sensitive memo content. **Overleaf and commercial chatbots are not.** Never paste CUI, PHI, or real PII into them. **If your memo contains CUI, skip Overleaf** — compile it on your own computer instead (see the back), so nothing leaves your machine.

2. You sign it, you own it. AI invents names, dates, and regulation numbers with total confidence — a wrong reg number looks exactly as authoritative as a right one. The sample prompt tells it to leave blanks instead of guessing. Read every line before it goes out; "the AI wrote it" is not a defense.

OPTIONAL

The fast path above is a complete, permanent solution — many people never need more. If you make memos often, here are two setups that remove the copy-paste. Skip this page until you want it.

First, what you were actually doing. That “block of code” is **LaTeX** (say “LAY-tek”), a typesetting system. A *compiler* turns it into the finished PDF — that’s what Overleaf did. The reason the format is always perfect is the class file `armymemo.cls`: it encodes every AR 25-50 rule, so you and the AI only supply the words. The two upgrades below just move the writing and the compiling onto your own computer so there’s no carrying files between two websites.

TWO FASTER SETUPS

Claude Cowork

DESKTOP AGENT · WRITES THE FILE FOR YOU

Need: the [Claude desktop app](#) ([Cowork](#), on any paid plan — Pro or higher).

- Put the starter-kit folder in your Documents folder.
- Open the app, click **Cowork**, point it at that folder, grant access.
- Tell it: “Using the armymemo template here, write an MFR about [your facts]. Save it as a new .tex file. Don’t make anything up — leave blanks.”
- It writes the file for you. For the PDF, hand the file to Overleaf, or compile locally if you’ve installed LaTeX (see below).

Claude Code in VS Code

THE WAY I DO IT IN CLASS · MOST SETUP, LEAST EFFORT AFTER

Need: VS Code, Claude Code, and LaTeX installed (below). One-time setup; then it’s the fastest.

- Open a folder containing `armymemo.cls` + `D0Db1.pdf` in VS Code; start Claude Code.
- Ask in plain English: “Using armymemo.cls here, write an MFR about [facts], leave blanks for anything missing, then compile twice with lualatex and open the PDF.”
- It writes the memo, compiles it, and opens the PDF — no copy-paste, and nothing leaves your machine.
- Iterate by talking. (In class I use a custom `/memo` skill that also auto-loads the regs — [AR 25-50](#), the [Tongue & Quill](#) — you can build one once you’re comfortable.)

COMPILING ON YOUR OWN COMPUTER (NEEDED FOR BOTH UPGRADES, AND FOR ANY CUI MEMO)

Install [MacTeX](#) ([tug.org/mactex](#), for Mac) or [TeX Live](#) ([tug.org/texlive](#), for Windows/Linux) — one time, a few GB. Then keep `armymemo.cls` and `D0Db1.pdf` in the same folder as your `.tex` file and run, twice, in a terminal: `lualatex memo.tex && lualatex memo.tex`. The PDF appears next to the file. Because it’s all on your machine, this path is safe for CUI. (The memo uses Times New Roman + Arial; Mac and Overleaf have them, a bare Linux box may need the `msttcorefonts` package first.)

WHICH IS WHICH

METHOD	SETUP	EFFORT PER MEMO	STAYS ON YOUR COMPUTER?	BEST FOR
Ask Sage → Overleaf	None — browser only	~3 min (copy-paste)	No — uses Overleaf	Everyone’s starting point; all most people need
Claude Cowork	Desktop app, paid plan	~2 min, no copy-paste	Writing yes; PDF if LaTeX installed	Frequent memos, non-technical
Claude Code	Most — app + LaTeX	Fastest — one line	Yes — fully local (CUI-safe)	Power users; sensitive content

WHAT’S IN THE STARTER KIT (ATTACHED ZIP)

- `sample-prompt.md` — the ready-to-paste prompt for Part A (no uploads).
 - `D0Db1.pdf` — the DoD seal. Upload to Overleaf too.
 - `mfr-template.tex` — a blank fill-in memo, if you’d rather start by hand.
 - `digsig.sty` — optional; ignore unless you add a digital signature.
- `armymemo.cls` — the rulebook (all AR 25-50 formatting). Upload to Overleaf.
 - `mfr-template-EXAMPLE-output.pdf` — what a finished memo looks like.
 - `README.txt` — the same steps, in the folder.

Bottom line: do the fast path tonight — you’ll have a compliant MFR in about 15 minutes, and you never have to touch the other two methods unless you want to go faster. Stuck on a step? Reach out anytime — happy to screen-share. — LTC Jared Black